

CAPITAL SHIPS

Although the term “capital ship” was not actually defined until the 1920s, by the outbreak of World War I it was already being applied to the most powerful craft in the fleet: battleships and battlecruisers, which sacrificed armour for speed as a means of protecting themselves. Battleships seemed to dominate the field of naval warfare during World War I, but in fact the expected large-scale battle between the German and British fleets did not materialize. After the war, they bore the brunt of internationally mandated cuts, but their heyday was already past in any case. In the early stages of World War II they proved themselves sickeningly vulnerable to air attack, and the pride-of-place they once enjoyed passed to the aircraft carrier.

► HMS DREADNOUGHT

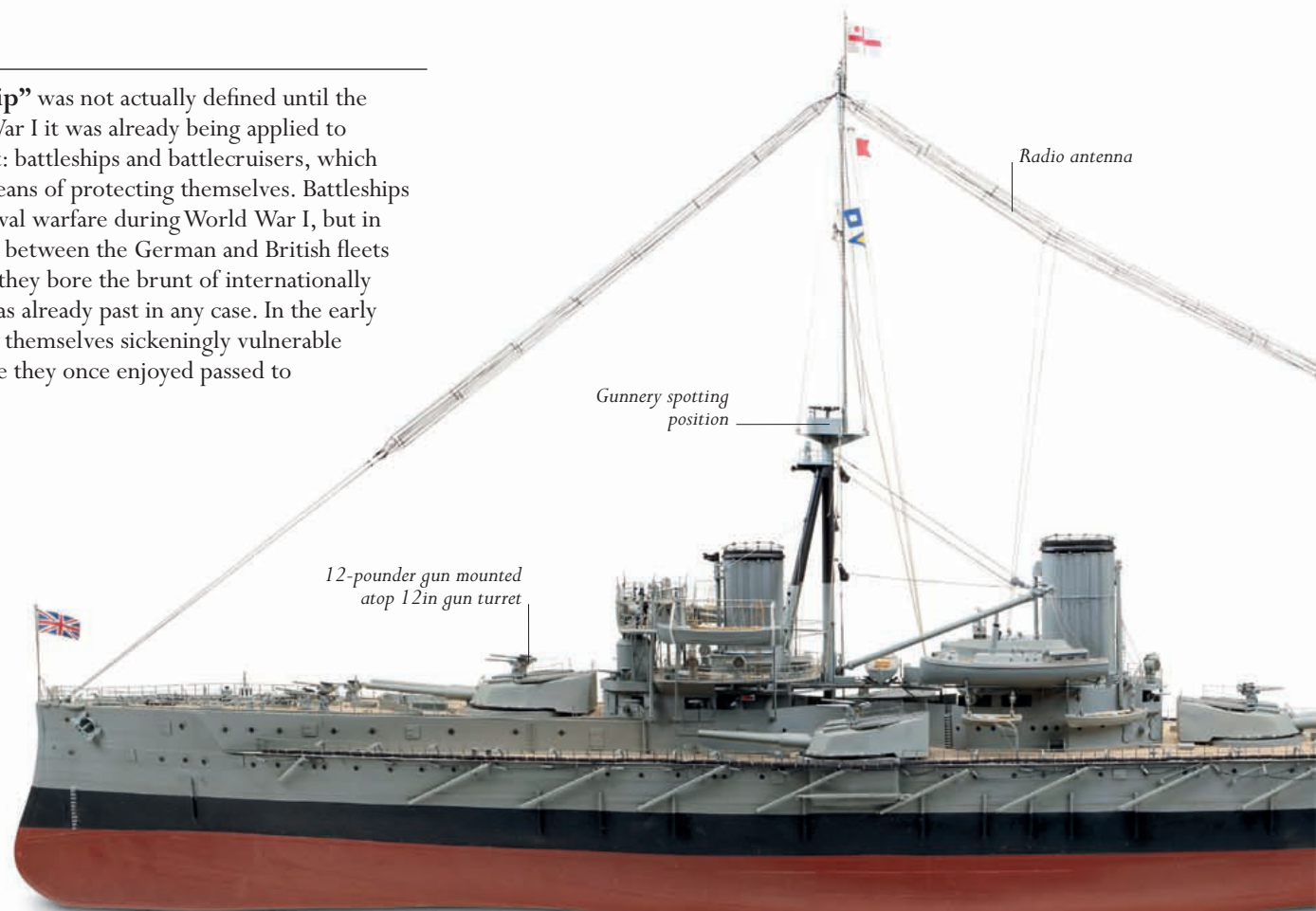
Commissioned 1906 **Origin** UK

Displacement 21,845 tons

Length 160.6m (527ft)

Top speed 21 knots

Dreadnought was ground-breaking in two respects: it was armed with big guns in all turrets and no “intermediates”, and it was propelled by turbines, which both saved weight and increased speed. It was also better armoured than previous ships.



▼ SMS DERFFLINGER

Commissioned 1914 **Origin** Germany

Displacement 30,700 tons

Length 210.4m (690ft)

Top speed 26.5 knots

Derfflinger was one of the 52 German ships scuttled at Scapa Flow on 21 June 1919, and was the last to be raised, in 1939. It was the German navy's fourth-generation battlecruiser, and was far superior to the British Royal Navy's versions.

▼ HMS QUEEN MARY

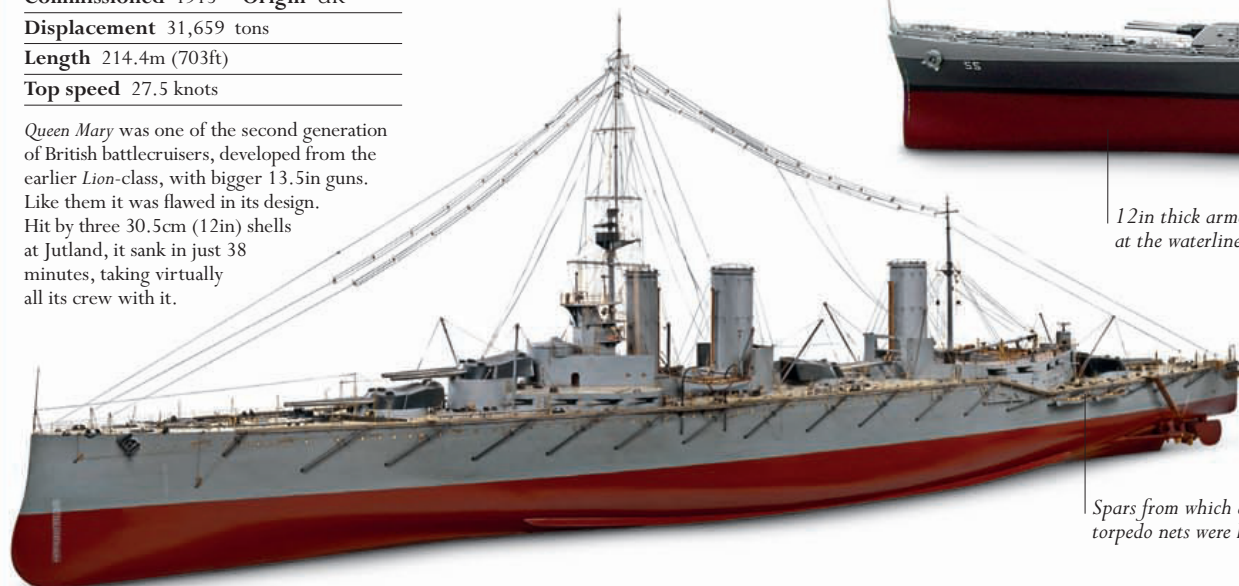
Commissioned 1913 **Origin** UK

Displacement 31,659 tons

Length 214.4m (703ft)

Top speed 27.5 knots

Queen Mary was one of the second generation of British battlecruisers, developed from the earlier *Lion*-class, with bigger 13.5in guns. Like them it was flawed in its design. Hit by three 30.5cm (12in) shells at Jutland, it sank in just 38 minutes, taking virtually all its crew with it.



12in thick armour belt at the waterline

Spars from which anti-torpedo nets were hung